

Rule Forty-Three: A Sink Is a Stage If You Commit

I had the flat to myself till six, and a flat to myself is a terrible thing to waste.

So I cleaned it. All of it. There's a particular joy to housework when no one's ever made you do it and no one's watching you do it — it's just you and a sponge and the radio and the slow honest math of a place getting better because of your hands. I did the floors. I did the windows she says don't open and which open if you respect them. I got three months of grime off the cooker hood and felt like a man who'd summited something. And then I did the dishes, the whole leaning tower of them, sleeves up and then the shirt off entirely because the water kept catching me down the front and a wet shirt is a worse companion than no shirt, and I had the place loud with a song I was absolutely murdering when the door went.

She stopped two steps in. Keys in hand. Looked at me at the sink. Looked at the gleaming flat. Looked back at me.

"Welcome home," I said, over my shoulder, elbow-deep in suds. "Don't mind the renaissance."

"You're doing dishes."

"I'm doing all the things. Dishes are the encore." I rinsed a bowl, set it in the rack with a flourish nobody asked for. "I found your cooker hood. There was a cooker hood under there the whole time. Archaeology."

She didn't answer. I let the quiet run a second, because I could feel the shape of it — the specific quiet of a woman trying very hard to keep her eyes at counter height and losing, by degrees, to gravity and the line of a wet back. I know that quiet. I've started living for that quiet.

"You can put your things down," I said, not turning around. "Or you can keep standing in the doorway holding your keys. Both are fine. One of them's a little obvious."

"I'm looking at the floor."

"The floor's down there." I turned, finally, drying my hands on the towel slung over my shoulder, and caught her at it — the exact instant her gaze made the climb and got intercepted and shot back up to my face, too late, the colour already going. "The floor's a real triumph, you're right to admire it. I'm proud of the floor."

"It's a clean floor."

"It's the cleanest floor in the building. You're allowed to be moved." I leaned back

against the sink, arms crossed, water still tracking down me, and let her have the moment, because the moment was so clearly costing her. "Take your time. I'll wait."

"I'm taking my shoes off."

"You're taking your shoes off at a very specific angle."

"There's no angle to taking shoes off."

"And yet." I tipped my head, grinning now, the whole grin, the one she pretends does nothing to her. "You came in, you saw a clean flat, you saw a man who built it, and your entire face filed a report it did not authorize. I watched it happen. It was beautiful. It was like watching one of your spreadsheets catch fire."

"I'm going to my room."

"Your room is also clean. I did your room. You're welcome." She turned, and I called after her, light, easy, "I left the bed alone. I have boundaries. I just wanted you to know there was a man with boundaries and a wet torso in your kitchen, available for comment—"

The pillow hit me in the chest. She has a good arm. I caught it on the rebound and held it to my heart like a medal.

"Put a shirt on," she said, from the hallway, not turning around, and her voice did the thing — dropped, just a half-step, the tell she can't audit out of it.

"It's wet," I said. "You want me cold? In my own kitchen? After I found your cooker hood?"

"Put on a dry shirt."

"It's across the room."

A pause from the hallway. The good kind. The kind I'd clean this flat a hundred times to earn.

"Then stay wet," she said — and the bedroom door clicked shut, slow, the latch taking its time, and the radio kept losing the same song in the corner, and the water went on tracking cold down my spine, and I'd swear on the gleaming floor I built her that she looked back, once, on the way through. Half a degree. I was there. I saw it.

I went back to the dishes. Murdered the next song worse than the first. And when she came out twenty minutes later in her soft clothes with her hair down and a folded dry shirt of mine in her hand, she set it on the counter beside me without a word, didn't look at me, and went to put the kettle on — and I put it on, still damp, just to watch her not say anything about the fact that I'd waited for her to be the one to hand it to me.

She made the tea. I did the last of the dishes. The radio kept losing the same song, and neither of us fixed it, and the flat stayed clean around us like something we were both, separately, refusing to break.